The right wing even paints him as ‘anti-Hindu’. However, the Yatra showed me a side of his personality that is completely hidden from the public.

During our daily morning stop, Digvijaya Singh would spread out a mattress in the farthest corner of our tent to do yoga and would then quietly pray. Once the prayers were over, he would give a piece of mishri (a sweet condiment) as prasad (blessing) to whoever was nearby. Then he would wrap everything up and get back to work. He unfailingly did this every single day of the Yatra. The sincerity of the ritual was powerful. It was totally silent and he did not involve anyone in it, nor did he ever talk about it. The public nature of the ritual, which was otherwise performed privately, was also forced due to the punishing schedule of the Yatra.

Ironically, the man who has been branded ‘anti-Hindu’ by the right wing is a staunch believer and practitioner of the faith. However, the important difference is that his faith is not an instrument of political mobilization—it is an intensely personal pursuit. This sincere expression of faith stood in sharp contrast to what is passed off as ‘Hinduness’ today, which is merely an ideological exhortation to majoritarianism and Hindu supremacy. This supremacy must be fought, but, more importantly, we must also strive to rescue the Hindu faith from being devoured by this ideological project.

In a deeply religious society, religion will always be a powerful force. We must attempt to popularize its humane aspects. Secularism today has somehow come to be identified with irreligiosity or, worse, a mindless elitist critique of the faith of common people. However, we must repopularize the Indian idea of secularism, which stands for equal respect for all religions, or *sarva dharma sambhava*.

These episodes also made me re-evaluate the relevance of the Gandhian ethos. I use the word ‘ethos’ because Gandhi ji was not an ideologue or a theorist. He was a practitioner constantly in an effort to improve himself ethically and morally. The Gandhian ethos, then, was an invitation to authentically pursue moral and political ideals. It demanded an emotional investment in politics so that one could live out the values that one espoused rather than just intellectually propagate them. Hence, it was more important to ‘feel’ rather than merely ‘think’ about poverty and God.